Pacific: Japan, South Korea, Australia, Thailand, and the Philippines. By contrast, India often seeks military partnership with many benefits but fewer dependencies and obligations. The benefits might include sharing of information such as strategic assessments, domain awareness, or intelligence; capacity-building through training, equipment sales, co-manufacturing, co-development or technological assistance; and increased interoperability through more complex and sophisticated military exercises, better communications integration, and coordinated operating procedures. Any kind of joint operations, if undertaken, are normally a political decision.

The United States is already India's most important security partner in the Indo–Pacific. The potential of this partnership began to be realized in the early 1990s, when initial military contacts began after the Cold War. After the 1998 nuclear tests, cooperation swiftly resumed. The administration of Bill Clinton lifted sanctions on India by October 1999, motivated by both commercial and strategic reasons, and for the first time the United States backed India in a crisis with Pakistan during the Kargil War of 1999. The George W. Bush administration was early to recognize the potential of India as a balancer, with his adviser Condoleezza Rice writing in 2000 that India could play a wider role in Asia. [35] In 2005, this was put into action with a senior official announcing that the United States' 'goal is to help India become a major world power in the 21st century . . . We understand fully the implications, including military implications of that statement'. [36] This meant an appreciation that, in the analyst Ashley Tellis's words, 'a strong, democratic, (even if perpetually) independent India [is] in American national interest'. [37] This eventually resulted in the civil nuclear agreement announced in July 2005, which bid to lift various technology export controls and political restraints on India. That agreement, finalized in 2008, culminated in a waiver by the Nuclear Suppliers Group, marking an effective end to India's nuclear isolation.

While it began its tenure by exploring avenues of cooperation with China, the Barack Obama administration eventually came to similar conclusions as its predecessors about India. In her 2011 essay that first